

Anime tattoos, 60-hour gaming marathons, and Olympic gold – the fascinating world of Mete Gazoz

The 26-year-old Turkish archer who once battled a severe stutter now **lets his arrows do the talking** on the world stage.

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It's fair to say Mete Gazoz enjoyed his first visit to India earlier this month. He was in the country to participate in the Archery Premier League, a 10-day, team-based competition, but still found time to visit historic monuments, browse malls, and sample local cuisine. Mete did well in the League, too. His team, the Rajputana Royals, went on to win the inaugural season. Long before he lifted the trophy, though, fans at New Delhi's Yamuna Sports Complex were already getting the 26-year-old to perform his trademark victory celebration.

You'd think Mete would tire of it, especially when fans asked him to do it right after training, but he indulged them every time, theatrically raising his right hand before clenching it in front of his face. Mete says he's used to the unusual request.

While Yusuf Dikec's nonchalant pistol-shooting pose became a viral sensation at the Paris Olympics, Mete was the original Turkish precision athlete to have a viral Olympic moment.

Mete's gesture was iconic on its own, but it was the fact that he pulled it off moments after winning men's singles gold, Turkey's first Olympic gold in archery, that made him a breakout star back home.

"My life really changed after that gold medal," he tells *Sportstar*. "For a few months, it was crazy. It's a bit easier now, but if I ever wear the national-team T-shirt, people are going to be looking at me or asking to take my picture. It's not the worst thing. But it's made me a bit more discreet. I tend to walk a little faster so people can't catch up to me, and if I'm at a restaurant, I can quickly figure out who recognises me, so I'll sit facing away from them," he says.

Mete has found a way not to be burdened by the expectations that

come with success. He's learned to channel the pressure that accompanies Olympic glory into composure and focus on the range.

Old promise

For a long time, the pose was thought to be inspired by his love of anime. Gazoz has multiple tattoos of characters from *One Piece*, but the real story is much simpler.

"I made my international debut for the senior Turkey team when I was 14. At that time, one of my teammates and I decided that if either of us ever won a world title, we'd do this pose. It was just something silly we decided together. When I first won a World Cup title (the 2018 World Cup Final), I decided to fulfil that promise. A lot of people think I'm paying tribute to something



I want to win an Olympic team gold and the mixed-team gold. I haven't won those yet. I don't think I'm very far from it. It's all a matter of one arrow.